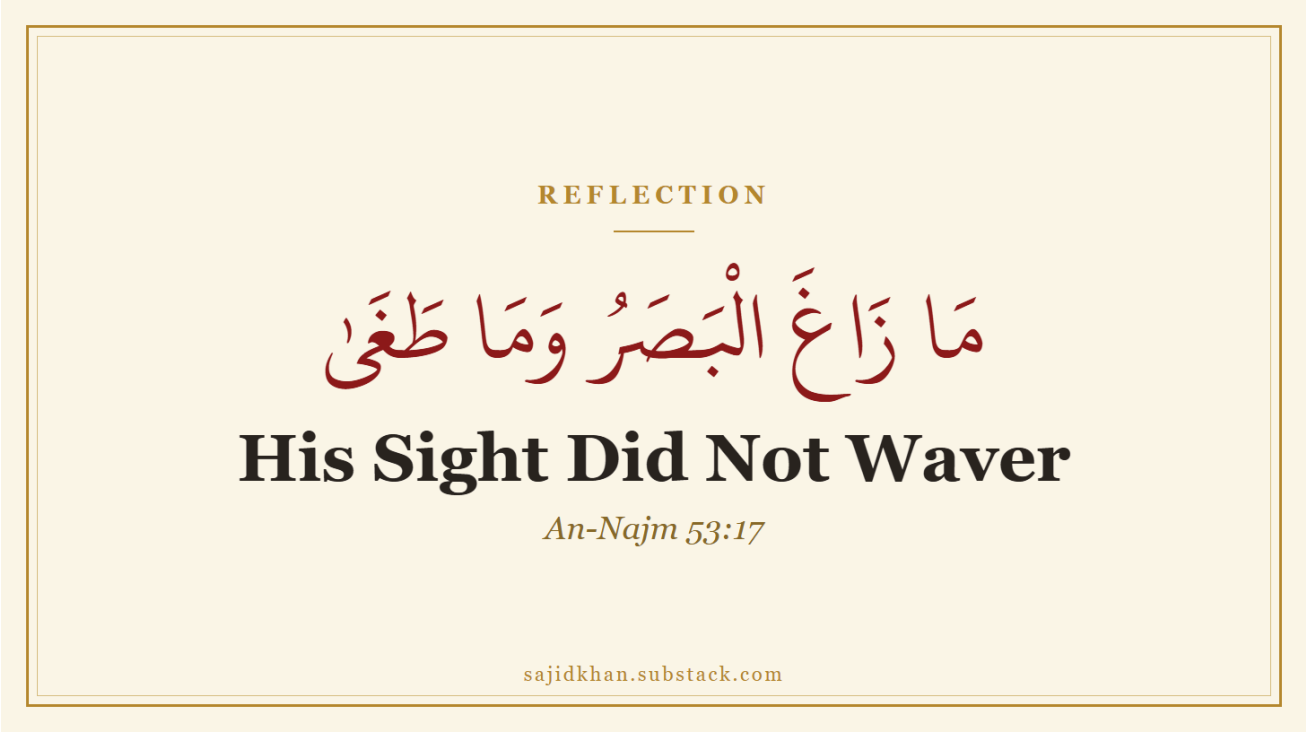


REFLECTION

His Sight Did Not Waver

The Prophet ﷺ on the night of the Mi'raj (53:17)

Surah An-Najm describes what the Prophet ﷺ saw on the night of the Mi'raj (مِعْرَاج, "the ascent"). One short ayah says how he looked at it (53:17): مَا زَاغَ الْبَصَرُ وَمَا طَغَىٰ *"His sight did not swerve, nor did it go beyond the limit."*

And the next ayah (53:18):

لَقَدْ رَأَىٰ مِنْ آيَاتِ رَبِّهِ الْكُبْرَىٰ ﴿١٨﴾

"He truly saw some of the greatest signs of his Lord."

Calm before the greatest signs

The Prophet ﷺ saw the greatest signs of his Lord, and the Qur'an praises the way he looked. مَا زَاغَ "it did not swerve": he did not look away in fear or confusion. وَمَا طَغَىٰ "it did not overstep": he did not stare about beyond what he was shown. He stood in that place with complete calm and good manners.

Allama Iqbal saw in this the ideal of perfect manhood in Islam. He quotes a Persian verse about the Prophet ﷺ: "Moses fainted away at a mere surface illumination of Reality; you see the very substance of Reality with a smile." Musa, peace be upon him, fell unconscious when his Lord manifested Himself to the mountain (7:143). The Prophet ﷺ saw the greatest signs and remained himself.

Get the free lessons: a new grammar post or reflection every Tuesday and Thursday at sajidkhan.substack.com. More lessons at ibnqutb.com; books and apps at seemabooks.com.